



Austin 7, 1930

Cars for everyone

Car production increased greatly in the 1910s and 1920s, as new designs and manufacturing techniques reduced prices and made cars more affordable. The Austin 7, for instance, cost just £165 (around \$200) at its 1922 launch, and 290,000 cars were produced by 1939.

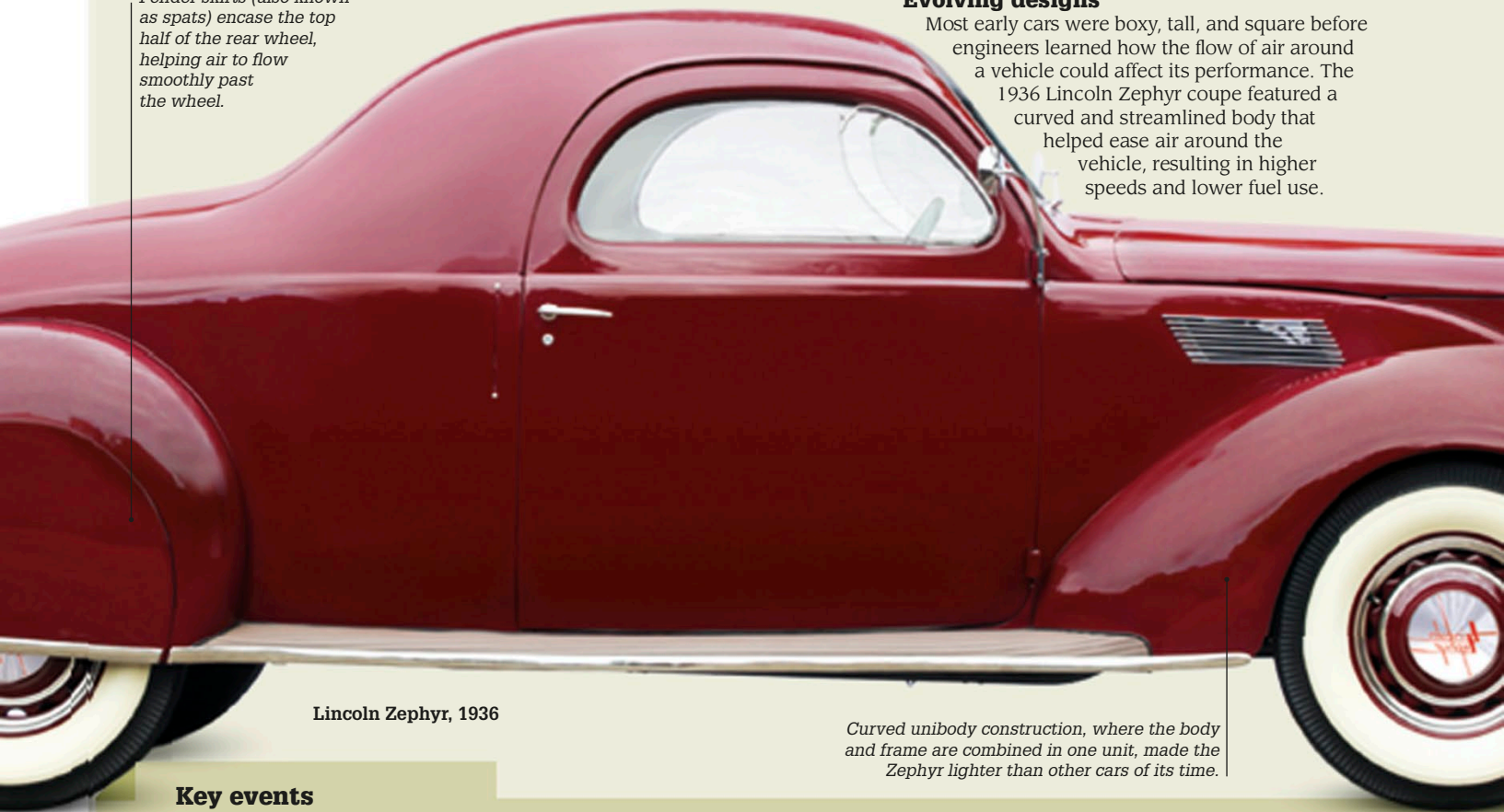
Fender skirts (also known as spats) encase the top half of the rear wheel, helping air to flow smoothly past the wheel.

Driving around

The 20th century saw a phenomenal boom in motor vehicle production as cars and trucks went from being rare novelties to a vital mode of transportation used every day. In the United States, for example, there were just four officially registered cars in 1895. By 2016, the number had increased to more than 254 million. Innovations in car design and features—from streamlined body shapes to electric starting and automatic gearboxes—helped spur the phenomenal increase in motor vehicle use.

Evolving designs

Most early cars were boxy, tall, and square before engineers learned how the flow of air around a vehicle could affect its performance. The 1936 Lincoln Zephyr coupe featured a curved and streamlined body that helped ease air around the vehicle, resulting in higher speeds and lower fuel use.



Lincoln Zephyr, 1936

Curved unibody construction, where the body and frame are combined in one unit, made the Zephyr lighter than other cars of its time.

Key events

1894

The Benz Velo was the first car built in significant numbers, with more than 1,200 produced. Its 3 horsepower (hp) engine gave it a top speed of 12 mph (19 km/h).

1896

The first electric starter was installed on a car in London. Electric starters dispensed with the need to turn a crank at the front of the car to start the engine.

1902

The Oldsmobile Curved Dash became the first mass-produced car. More than 19,000 of this two-seater were built on an assembly line using interchangeable parts.

1908

Henry Ford's Model T car ushered in an era of affordable motoring, especially when his efficient new factory opened and the car price dropped.

Ford Model T

